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Chairman
Harsh
Mariwala,
who comes
from a
business**

family, set up the consumer products business practically from scratch. Over the past four decades, he has not only built Marico into one of the leading FMCG companies in the country, but has also transformed what was essentially a family-managed business into a professionally managed one. Mariwala, who has seen the FMCG space transform over the past few years, says Marico views every disruption as an opportunity. In a candid conversation with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, Mariwala talks about the learnings from failure, succession planning and what the future holds for the company. Edited excerpts:

Q: Harsh, if you had to assess your own career over the last four decades, would you be fully satisfied? Had you been told as a young man that this is how it will pan out, would you have grabbed it with both hands?

A: The short answer is yes, Udayan. But let me delve a little deeper in terms of what I expected from myself and how it all turned out. So, first of all, I am just a graduate; I have not done anything beyond my B. Com. Yet, at the very outset, I was absolutely clear that I was not going to work for anybody else. I had to run my own business. So, from that point of view, full marks; I never worked for anybody else. I joined the family business at a very young age of 20 and built this business of consumer products [Marico] virtually from scratch. It was completely a family-managed organisation. There were no professionals; there was no one to teach me, and we were not in consumer products to begin with, so I had to start virtually from

the bottom. I had to travel to rural areas, appoint distributors—even stay with the distributors in small towns where there were no hotels.

Then, we appointed an ad agency and the first thing I told them was that I wanted to spend one week with them to understand how advertising is created. So, this experience of learning everything from scratch has really helped me in terms of understanding how things work at the bottom. And then matters were complicated by my large family, my father, three of my uncles, followed by five of my cousins in the same company. So, how you untangle yourself in a large family was a big challenge for me. It took two to three years, [and] I had to show a lot of patience. But, ultimately that also worked out. So, I have no regrets. Overall, I feel good that I was able to start from scratch and build a company of good repute, before passing it on to professionals. Marico has transitioned from an owner-managed company to a strategic investor-led company.

Q: Nor should you have any regrets. I've been reading all of this in your wonderful biography, *Harsh Realities*, where you mention that you tried to get into business schools as a young man but failed to get admission. This, you say, was a blessing in disguise. Why?

A: You are absolutely right. I tried getting into business schools in India. Then, I wanted to go abroad but my father said no—he was wise enough to know that when I came back and joined the family business later, I would be deeply frustrated. After all, in a typically family-

“I have created Marico from a perpetuity point of view, and not to sell it. I am preparing it from a long-term point of view in terms of the role of the board and what kind of decisions it will take over a period of time”

managed business, there are no systems, no professionals. Similarly, had I come in after doing an MBA, I would not have gone through the learning curve which I had to, simply because I was not qualified, [and did